

SHOW OF DEFIANCE
Left, Chinmoy Krishna Das being taken away by the police in Chattogram, Nov. 26

1996-97, Das claims "some [divine] intervention" brought him to the revered monk Jaypataka Swami, a disciple of International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) founder Swami Prabhupada. Das received his religious initiation in 2000, and became monk-president of the Dham in 2007. When, as spokesperson of the newly-formed minority body Bangladesh Sommilito Sanatan Jagaran Jot, the now 39-year-old Das organised rallies protesting communal attacks on minorities, his charisma and oratory attracted large crowds. And when the Bangladesh police arrested him on November 25 from the Dhaka airport on charges of sedition and denied him bail thereafter, Das became a *cause celebre* in the ongoing tussle over the security of Bangladesh's embattled minorities.

In an FIR lodged on October 31, former BNP activist Md Feroze Khan alleged that Das and 18 others had hoisted a saffron flag above the Bangladesh national flag—claiming it to an act of sedition—at the Zero point crossing of the city on October 10. Satantra Das, a close companion of the monk, claims Islamic organisations like Jamaat-e-Islami and Hefazat-e-Islami often hoist their flags above the national flag. "If they are not anti-national, how is Chinmoy Prabhu accused of the same crime?" he asks. Das was advocating the 'eight-point demand' of the Jot, which included a tribunal to hear cases of atrocities against minorities and implementation of a minority protection act. In Chattogram, four incidents of attacks on temples have been reported from Sebok Colony, Firingi Bazar and Hajari Goli. Das's arrest was followed by India expressing "deep concern" about denial of bail to him and about atrocities against Hindus. Calls to release him have intensified in India, especially in West Bengal.

On November 26, many of Das's supporters protesting his arrest clashed with the police in Chattogram during which a lawyer, Saiful Islam, was killed. It led to a call to ban ISKCON, which denied having a hand in the event and distanced itself from Das, saying he had been suspended in October on charges of child abuse.

Das's arrest and the initial denial of bail elicited a sharp reaction from New Delhi. Since then, calls to release him have intensified across India

However, Satantra says Das was never officially removed. He alleges internal jealousy instead. "After Chinmoy took over in 2007, Pundarik Dham transformed into a hub of activity. He reclaimed lands allegedly grabbed by politicians. His success made him a target of envy within ISKCON," he says. Two of the three boys who accused him of abuse told INDIA TODAY that they made their accusations under pressure. "We came under the influence of others to malign the president," they say.

Das has amassed a following among Hindu youth, attracting thousands to his rallies. Among those won over by Das's personality is renowned poet and philosopher Farhad Mazhar, who calls the sedition charges misuse of a colonial-era law. "In my interactions with Chinmoy, I never felt he was anti-national," he says.

However, Das's meteoric rise has drawn criticism too. Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) leaders have accused him of being an Awami League plant who aims to destabilise the interim government. "How did he become so popular? His activities are fishy and it seems AL is behind his rise," says Salahuddin Ahmed, a former BNP MP.

On December 11, a local court rejected the plea to advance his bail hearing on technical grounds. When no lawyer had appeared on his behalf on December 3, it was set for January 2, 2025. There will be no succour for Das in 2024. ■